

# Psalms 87

## *Glorious Things of Zion*

Glorious things are spoken of thee, O city of God  
KJV · Standalone study handout

### 1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *His foundation is in the holy mountains.*
- 2 *The LORD loveth the gates of Zion more than all the dwellings of Jacob.*
- 3 *Glorious things are spoken of thee, O city of God. Selah.*
- 4 *I will make mention of Rahab and Babylon to them that know me: behold Philistia, and Tyre, with Ethiopia; this man was born there.*
- 5 *And of Zion it shall be said, This and that man was born in her: and the highest himself shall establish her.*
- 6 *The LORD shall count, when he writeth up the people, that this man was born there. Selah.*
- 7 *As well the singers as the players on instruments shall be there: all my springs are in thee.*

### 2 · CONTEXT

A brief but striking psalm celebrating Zion not merely as a location but as a spiritual birthplace, extending citizenship to people from historically hostile or foreign nations—Egypt (Rahab), Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Ethiopia are all pictured as having citizens registered as 'born' in Zion. Henry and later commentators read this as an early anticipation of the gospel's reach beyond Israel, a vision of God's city drawing in the nations rather than merely excluding them.

### 3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

*The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.*

#### Verse 1-3

Zion's foundation is described as being on God's own holy mountains, loved by Him above every other dwelling place in Jacob. The declaration that 'glorious things are spoken of you, city of God' sets the tone for what follows—Zion's honor is not military or economic but spiritual.

#### Verse 4-7

Remarkably, God is pictured naming historically foreign or hostile peoples—Egypt, Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, Ethiopia—and registering individuals from among them as citizens 'born' in Zion, established by the Most High Himself. The psalm closes with a picture of singers and dancers celebrating together, declaring that all their springs of joy and life are found in Zion.

### 4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

#### Meaning.

Zion's true glory is not exclusivity but the surprising breadth of who God registers as belonging there—citizens drawn even from nations that had once opposed His people. The psalm anticipates a community defined by spiritual birth rather than ethnic origin, with every source of joy and life ultimately traced back to this city of God.

#### Application for life today.

Let this psalm challenge any tendency to define belonging in God's community more narrowly than God Himself does—He delights in registering citizens from unexpected, even formerly hostile, backgrounds. Consider who in your own circles might currently feel like an outsider to faith, and how this psalm's vision of inclusion should shape your welcome. Let the psalm's closing joy remind you that every genuine spring of gladness in your life ultimately traces back to belonging to God's city.

### 5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

*Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.*

1. Where do you need to widen your sense of who belongs in God's community, following this psalm's surprising inclusion of former enemies (vv. 4–6)?

2. What would it mean to genuinely believe that your deepest joys 'spring' from your citizenship in God's city (v. 7), rather than from circumstances?

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3. Who in your life might need to hear that they, too, could be registered as 'born' into God's people, regardless of their background?

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Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Group / Church: \_\_\_\_\_

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).